

A single kinetic defect in a run-and-tumble ring: exact spectrum, exceptional points, and relaxation crossover

Abstract. We solve the spectral problem for one continuous-time run-and-tumble particle on an n -site ring when the tumbling rate at one site is ω_0 and the bulk rate is ω . The defect changes the $2n \times 2n$ generator by rank one. The characteristic polynomial is the homogeneous polynomial plus $(\omega_0 - \omega)/n$ times its ω -derivative. This identity gives Chebyshev and transfer-matrix quantization formulas, a parity factorization, and finite polynomial tests for every Jordan block. We separately resolve the singular flat-band point $\omega = 1$, where the eigenvalue -2 can carry Jordan blocks of sizes two or three. The infinite-line Green function gives an exact criterion for exponentially localized defect modes. For fixed positive bulk rate, reflection protects one homogeneous long-wave mode; consequently a slow defect, including $\omega_0 \asymp n^{-1}$, does not produce a new spectral-gap scaling. The nontrivial n^{-1} crossover occurs when the bulk rate itself is of order n^{-1} . Finally, the standard telegraph equation misses the lattice Poisson-diffusion term at fixed ω , while a diffusion-corrected telegraph equation agrees through order n^{-2} .

Keywords. Run-and-tumble particle; kinetic defect; non-Hermitian spectrum; exceptional point; localized mode; spectral gap; telegraph equation.

1. Introduction

Persistent random walks provide a microscopic description of motion with a finite directional memory. Continuum random-walk formulations of biased chemotactic motion arise, for example, in [Sch93], while lattice run-and-tumble models retain the individual hopping and reversal events and connect directly to nonequilibrium particle systems [TTCB11]. For a homogeneous ring, the one-particle spectrum, its exceptional points, and the associated relaxation transition are known explicitly [MBE19]. Spatial inhomogeneity has been studied through position-dependent speed [AG19], quenched disorder in speed and tumbling [BWK⁺19, Secs. 2.1.2–2.1.3 and 2.2.2–2.2.3], and saturating space-dependent rates on the line [JC24, Sec. II, Eqs. (3)–(4)]. Those works emphasize probability laws, steady states, or relaxation in extended media. The present problem instead asks for the full finite-ring characteristic polynomial and Jordan structure of a single lattice tumbling defect, together with its large-ring spectral ordering.

This paper asks how that spectral picture changes when the tumbling rate is altered at one site. The inhomogeneity is local but the generator is non-normal, so eigenvalue crossings, Jordan structure, and long-wave relaxation must be tracked together. The central observation is that the defect is rank one in the polarization channel. It leads to a finite characteristic identity, a parity decomposition, an infinite-line Green-function criterion including a compact defect mode, and a direct comparison between lattice and telegraph relaxation. The fixed-rate and bulk-critical limits separate the effects of a local defect from those of a vanishing bulk tumbling rate.

2. Model and notation

Definition 2.1 (Defective run-and-tumble generator). Let $n \geq 2$, let $\omega > 0$, and let $\omega_0 \geq 0$. Sites are $j \in \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$, orientations are $\sigma \in \{+, -\}$, and

$$\omega_j = \begin{cases} \omega_0, & j = 0, \\ \omega, & j \neq 0. \end{cases}$$

The forward generator $L = L_n(\omega, \omega_0)$ is

$$(Lu)_j^+ = u_{j-1}^+ - (1 + \omega_j)u_j^+ + \omega_j u_j^-, \quad (2.1)$$

$$(Lu)_j^- = u_{j+1}^- - (1 + \omega_j)u_j^- + \omega_j u_j^+. \quad (2.2)$$

Thus hopping in the current orientation has rate one and tumbling has rate ω_j . Put

$$\delta = \omega_0 - \omega, \quad q_k = \frac{2\pi k}{n}, \quad c_k = \cos q_k, \quad s_k = \sin q_k.$$

Equations (2.1)–(2.2) use the same one-particle convention as equations (6)–(10) of [MBE19]. That paper records the homogeneous eigenvalues in its equation (11), the homogeneous exceptional points in equation (14), and the first-mode relaxation rate in equations (20)–(21).

Lemma 2.2 (Rank-one defect). Let $L^{(0)} = L_n(\omega, \omega)$. If $d = e_{0,+} - e_{0,-}$, then

$$L = L^{(0)} - \delta dd^\top.$$

In particular, the perturbation has rank one when $\delta \neq 0$.

Proof. At site zero, changing ω to ω_0 adds

$$\delta \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 1 \\ 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} = -\delta \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ -1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Every other matrix entry is unchanged. ■

3. Three exact characteristic equations

Definition 3.1 (Homogeneous factors). For $\lambda \in \mathbb{C}$, set

$$a = \lambda + 1 + \omega, \quad (3.1)$$

$$x = \frac{a^2 + 1 - \omega^2}{2a}, \quad (3.2)$$

$$D_k(\lambda) = (\lambda + 1 - c_k)(\lambda + 1 + 2\omega - c_k) + s_k^2 = a^2 + 1 - \omega^2 - 2ac_k. \quad (3.3)$$

Although x is undefined at $a = 0$, each expression below containing $a^n T_n(x)$ is understood by its unique polynomial continuation.

Lemma 3.2 (*Homogeneous polynomial*). The homogeneous characteristic polynomial is

$$\begin{aligned} P_n^{(0)}(\lambda; \omega) &= \det(\lambda I - L^{(0)}) \\ &= \prod_{k=0}^{n-1} D_k(\lambda) \end{aligned} \quad (3.4)$$

$$= 2a^n (T_n(x) - 1), \quad (3.5)$$

where T_n is the Chebyshev polynomial of the first kind. The two roots of D_k are

$$\lambda_k^\pm = c_k - 1 - \omega \pm \sqrt{\omega^2 - s_k^2}.$$

Proof. Fourier transformation gives the block

$$W_k = \begin{pmatrix} e^{iq_k} - 1 - \omega & \omega \\ \omega & e^{-iq_k} - 1 - \omega \end{pmatrix}.$$

Its characteristic polynomial is D_k , which proves (3.4) and the displayed roots. Since $D_k = 2a(x - c_k)$ and

$$\prod_{k=0}^{n-1} (x - c_k) = 2^{1-n} (T_n(x) - 1),$$

equation (3.5) follows. ■

Theorem 3.3 (*Exact finite characteristic polynomial*). For every $n \geq 2$, $\omega > 0$, and $\omega_0 \geq 0$,

$$P_n(\lambda; \omega, \omega_0) := \det(\lambda I - L_n(\omega, \omega_0)) \quad (3.6)$$

$$= P_n^{(0)}(\lambda; \omega) + \frac{\delta}{n} \partial_\omega P_n^{(0)}(\lambda; \omega) \quad (3.7)$$

$$= P_n^{(0)}(\lambda; \omega) \left[1 + \frac{2\delta}{n} \sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \frac{\lambda + 1 - c_k}{D_k(\lambda)} \right]. \quad (3.8)$$

Equation (3.8) is interpreted by polynomial continuation at a homogeneous eigenvalue. Equivalently,

$$P_n = 2a^n (T_n(x) - 1) + 2\delta a^{n-1} (T_n(x) - 1) + \delta a^{n-2} \lambda(\lambda + 2) U_{n-1}(x), \quad (3.9)$$

where U_{n-1} is the Chebyshev polynomial of the second kind and the right-hand side again denotes its polynomial continuation.

Proof. Let $B = \lambda I - L^{(0)}$. Lemma 2.2 and the matrix determinant lemma give

$$\det(\lambda I - L) = \det B(1 + \delta d^\top B^{-1} d).$$

In Fourier space,

$$d^\top B^{-1} d = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \frac{2(\lambda + 1 - c_k)}{D_k(\lambda)},$$

which proves (3.8). Direct differentiation of (3.4) gives

$$\partial_\omega P_n^{(0)} = P_n^{(0)} \sum_k \frac{2(\lambda + 1 - c_k)}{D_k},$$

and hence (3.7). Finally,

$$\partial_\omega x = \frac{\lambda(\lambda + 2)}{2a^2}, \quad T'_n(x) = nU_{n-1}(x),$$

and differentiating (3.5) proves (3.9). ■

Theorem 3.4 (*Transfer-matrix quantization*). For a local rate $r \geq 0$, define

$$T_r(\lambda) = \frac{1}{\lambda + 1 + r} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & r \\ -r & (\lambda + 1 + r)^2 - r^2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Then $\det T_r = 1$, and, away from the displayed denominators,

$$P_n(\lambda; \omega, \omega_0) = a^{n-1}(\lambda + 1 + \omega_0) \{ \text{tr}[T_\omega(\lambda)^{n-1} T_{\omega_0}(\lambda)] - 2 \}.$$

After multiplication by the denominators, this identity holds for every λ by polynomial continuation. When $a \neq 0$ and $\lambda + 1 + \omega_0 \neq 0$, an eigenvalue is equivalently characterized by

$$\text{tr}[T_\omega(\lambda)^{n-1} T_{\omega_0}(\lambda)] = 2.$$

At a zero of either denominator, the cleared polynomial identity (3.4), rather than the undefined trace in (3.4), is the eigenvalue criterion. Moreover, if $t = \text{tr} T_\omega = 2x$, then

$$T_\omega^{n-1} = U_{n-2}(x)T_\omega - U_{n-3}(x)I,$$

with $U_{-1} = 0$.

Proof. The eigenvalue equations at site j are

$$\begin{aligned} (\lambda + 1 + \omega_j)u_j^+ - \omega_j u_j^- &= u_{j-1}^+, \\ (\lambda + 1 + \omega_j)u_j^- - \omega_j u_j^+ &= u_{j+1}^-. \end{aligned}$$

Consequently

$$\begin{pmatrix} u_j^+ \\ u_{j+1}^- \end{pmatrix} = T_{\omega_j}(\lambda) \begin{pmatrix} u_{j-1}^+ \\ u_j^- \end{pmatrix}.$$

Periodic boundary conditions require the product monodromy to have eigenvalue one. Its determinant is one, so this is equivalent to trace two. To identify the polynomial, retain temporarily arbitrary rates $r_0, \dots, r_{n-1}$, denote the resulting generator by $L_n(r_0, \dots, r_{n-1})$, and put $b_j = \lambda + 1 + r_j$. Eliminate successively with the first equation at each site, whose pivot is b_j . The substituted second equations are precisely the recurrence for the pairs (u_{j-1}^+, u_j^-) displayed above. After one circuit the residual condition is $(M - I)(u_{n-1}^+, u_0^-)^\top = 0$, where $M = T_{r_{n-1}} \cdots T_{r_0}$. More explicitly, after the n pivots b_j , use the coefficients -1 of u_{j+1}^- in $n - 2$ consecutive recurrence equations as unit pivots. The two equations left are the displayed residual system, up to triangular row additions of determinant one. Hence the Schur-complement determinant is $\pm \prod_j b_j \det(M - I)$; comparison with the leading coefficient $+\lambda^{2n}$ fixes the sign as $-\prod_j b_j \det(M - I)$. Since $\det M = 1$, one has $-\det(M - I) = \text{tr } M - 2$. Consequently

$$\det(\lambda I - L_n(r_0, \dots, r_{n-1})) = \left(\prod_{j=0}^{n-1} b_j \right) [\text{tr}(T_{r_{n-1}} \cdots T_{r_0}) - 2]. \quad (3.10)$$

This is an identity of rational functions where all $b_j \neq 0$; multiplication by the displayed pivots makes both sides polynomials, so the identity extends to every λ . Taking $r_0 = \omega_0$ and all other rates equal to ω , and using cyclicity of the trace, gives (3.4), including algebraic multiplicities. Equation (3.4) is the Cayley–Hamilton identity for a unimodular 2×2 matrix. $\blacksquare$

4. Parity factorization and every finite exceptional point

Definition 4.1 (Kinetic reflection). Define the involution

$$(Ru)_j^+ = u_{-j}^-, \quad (Ru)_j^- = u_{-j}^+.$$

Write $\mathcal{H}_\pm = \ker(R \mp I)$.

Lemma 4.2 (*Protected sector*). *The generator commutes with R , the defect vector satisfies $Rd = -d$, and*

$$L|_{\mathcal{H}_+} = L^{(0)}|_{\mathcal{H}_+}.$$

Thus the defect changes only the reflection-odd sector.

Proof. Reflection reverses position and orientation simultaneously, leaving the directed hopping rules and the rate field ω_j invariant. At the fixed site zero it exchanges the two entries of d , hence $Rd = -d$. Lemma 2.2 then vanishes on $\mathcal{H}_+$. $\blacksquare$

Definition 4.3 (Parity polynomials). Put $m = \lfloor (n-1)/2 \rfloor$ and let ε_n be one for even n and zero for odd n . Define

$$H_{n,+}(\lambda) = \lambda(\lambda+2)^{\varepsilon_n} \prod_{k=1}^m D_k(\lambda), \quad (4.1)$$

$$H_{n,-}^{(0)}(\lambda) = (\lambda+2\omega)(\lambda+2+2\omega)^{\varepsilon_n} \prod_{k=1}^m D_k(\lambda), \quad (4.2)$$

$$G_n(\lambda) = \frac{1}{n} \left[\frac{1}{\lambda+2\omega} + \frac{\varepsilon_n}{\lambda+2+2\omega} + 2 \sum_{k=1}^m \frac{\lambda+1-c_k}{D_k(\lambda)} \right], \quad (4.3)$$

$$Q_{n,-}(\lambda) = H_{n,-}^{(0)}(\lambda)(1+2\delta G_n(\lambda)). \quad (4.4)$$

Every quotient in (4.4) cancels, so $Q_{n,-}$ is a monic polynomial of degree n . An entirely polynomial version is

$$\begin{aligned} Q_{n,-} = H_{n,-}^{(0)} + \frac{2\delta}{n} \left[\frac{H_{n,-}^{(0)}}{\lambda+2\omega} + \varepsilon_n \frac{H_{n,-}^{(0)}}{\lambda+2+2\omega} \right. \\ \left. + 2 \sum_{k=1}^m (\lambda+1-c_k) \frac{H_{n,-}^{(0)}}{D_k} \right]. \end{aligned} \quad (4.5)$$

Theorem 4.4 (Exact parity factorization). The characteristic polynomial factors as

$$P_n(\lambda; \omega, \omega_0) = H_{n,+}(\lambda) Q_{n,-}(\lambda).$$

The first factor is the characteristic polynomial on $\mathcal{H}_+$; the second is the characteristic polynomial on $\mathcal{H}_-$.

Proof. The modes q_k and $-q_k$ form a four-dimensional Fourier subspace, which splits into two isomorphic two-dimensional R -eigenspaces. Each has characteristic polynomial D_k . At $q = 0$, the vectors $(1, 1)$ and $(1, -1)$ have parities $+$ and $-$ and eigenvalues 0 and -2ω . When n is even, the $q = \pi$ density and polarization vectors have parities $+$ and $-$ and eigenvalues -2 and $-2-2\omega$. This gives (4.1)–(4.2). Lemma 4.2 and the rank-one determinant lemma restricted to $\mathcal{H}_-$ give (4.4). Multiplication proves (4.4). ■

Definition 4.5 (Exceptional point). For an eigenvalue μ , let $m_{\text{alg}}(\mu)$ be its algebraic multiplicity and $m_{\text{geo}}(\mu) = \dim \ker(\mu I - L)$ its geometric multiplicity. We call (ω, ω_0, μ) an exceptional point when $m_{\text{alg}}(\mu) > m_{\text{geo}}(\mu)$. Write $J_r(\mu)$ for a Jordan block of size r at μ .

Lemma 4.6 (No inter-wave coincidences away from the flat band). If $c_k \neq c_\ell$ and $D_k(\mu) = D_\ell(\mu) = 0$, then $\omega = 1$ and $\mu = -2$.

Proof. Subtracting the two equations gives $2a(c_k - c_\ell) = 0$, hence $a = 0$. Substitution into (3.3) gives $1 - \omega^2 = 0$. Since $\omega > 0$, this means $\omega = 1$ and then $\mu = -1 - \omega = -2$. ■

Theorem 4.7 (Jordan classification for $\omega \neq 1$). Assume $\omega \neq 1$.

1. In the protected sector, the endpoint factors in (4.1) give one-dimensional blocks. For each $1 \leq k \leq m$, a root of D_k gives one J_1 , except that

$$\omega = |s_k|, \quad \mu = c_k - 1 - \omega. \quad (4.6)$$

gives one $J_2(\mu)$.

2. In the affected sector, if

$$Q_{n,-}(\mu) = Q'_{n,-}(\mu) = \cdots = Q_{n,-}^{(r-1)}(\mu) = 0, \quad Q_{n,-}^{(r)}(\mu) \neq 0, \quad (4.7)$$

then the complete affected-sector contribution at μ is one block $J_r(\mu)$.

3. The full Jordan form at μ is the direct sum of the blocks in items 1 and 2. In particular, a crossing between the two parity sectors is semisimple unless one of its sector blocks has size greater than one.

Consequently, (4.6) together with (4.7) is an exact finite criterion for every exceptional point when $\omega \neq 1$. The order r in (4.7) classifies exceptional points of arbitrary order.

Proof. The discriminant of D_k is $4(\omega^2 - s_k^2)$. At a zero discriminant its Fourier block is not scalar and hence is a single J_2 ; otherwise each root is simple. Lemma 4.6 excludes coincidences between distinct c_k values.

It remains to show that the affected restriction is cyclic. In each two-dimensional homogeneous parity block, the spectral weight of the defect vector has numerator $2(\lambda + 1 - c_k)$. This numerator and D_k have no common root for an interior wave number: a common root would give $\lambda + 1 = c_k$, after which $D_k = s_k^2 \neq 0$. The endpoint weights in (4.3) are also nonzero. Lemma 4.6 makes the block minimal polynomials coprime. The defect vector is therefore cyclic for the homogeneous odd restriction. If A has cyclic vector d , then d is also cyclic for $A - \delta dd^\top$, because each $(A - \delta dd^\top)^j d$ equals $A^j d$ plus a linear combination of lower powers. Hence the minimal and characteristic polynomials of the affected restriction both equal $Q_{n,-}$. A cyclic matrix has one Jordan block for each eigenvalue, of size equal to the root order. The direct-sum assertion follows from the invariant parity splitting. ■

Theorem 4.8 (*The complete flat-band classification at $\omega = 1$*). Let $\omega = 1$ and put $\mu = -2$.

1. If $\omega_0 = 1$ and $4 \nmid n$, the contribution at μ is $nJ_1(\mu)$.
2. If $\omega_0 = 1$ and $4 \mid n$, the contribution is

$$2J_2(\mu) \oplus (n-2)J_1(\mu).$$

3. If $\omega_0 \neq 1$ and $n \equiv 1$ or $2 \pmod{4}$, the contribution is $(n-1)J_1(\mu)$.
4. If $\omega_0 \neq 1$ and $n \equiv 0 \pmod{4}$, the contribution is

$$J_2(\mu) \oplus (n-2)J_1(\mu).$$

5. If $n \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$, $\omega_0 \neq 1$, and $\omega_0 \neq (n-1)/(n+1)$, the contribution is again $J_2(\mu) \oplus (n-2)J_1(\mu)$.

6. If $n \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ and $\omega_0 = (n-1)/(n+1)$, the contribution is

$$J_3(\mu) \oplus (n-2)J_1(\mu).$$

For eigenvalues $\lambda \neq -2$, every protected-sector root is a one-dimensional block. Remove the exact power of $(\lambda+2)$ specified above from $Q_{n,-}$. Every root of the remaining affected polynomial contributes one Jordan block, so the derivative test (4.7) applied to that reduced polynomial classifies every remaining affected block at $\omega = 1$. The full Jordan form is the direct sum of the protected and affected blocks.

Proof. Write $t = \lambda + 2$. At $\omega = 1$,

$$D_k = t(t - 2c_k), \quad P_n = t^{n-1}F_n(t),$$

where, for $\delta = \omega_0 - 1$,

$$F_n(t) = 2t(T_n(t/2) - 1) + \delta [2(T_n(t/2) - 1) + (t-2)U_{n-1}(t/2)]. \quad (4.8)$$

The values

$$T_n(0) = \cos(n\pi/2), \quad U_{n-1}(0) = \sin(n\pi/2)$$

give the following algebraic multiplicities. For $\delta = 0$ they are n , except that $4 \mid n$ gives $n+2$. For $\delta \neq 0$ they are $n-1$ when $n \equiv 1, 2 \pmod{4}$, and n when $n \equiv 0, 3 \pmod{4}$. In the last congruence class, $F'_n(0) = -2 - \delta(n+1)$; it vanishes exactly at $\delta = -2/(n+1)$. For $n \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ one has $U''_{n-1}(0) = n^2 - 1$, and direct differentiation of (4.8) at the tuned value gives

$$F''_n(0) = -2n + \frac{U''_{n-1}(0)}{n+1} = -(n+1) \neq 0. \quad (4.9)$$

Thus the tuned multiplicity is $n+1$.

The bulk equations at $t = 0$ read

$$u_j^- = -u_{j-1}^+ \quad (j \neq 0).$$

Together they impose this relation for every j . The defect equation adds no constraint when $\omega_0 = 1$ and otherwise adds the single constraint $u_0^+ + u_{n-1}^+ = 0$. Thus the geometric multiplicity is n in the homogeneous case and $n-1$ otherwise. Fourier decomposition shows that the two excess algebraic dimensions when $4 \mid n$ and $\delta = 0$ are the two $q = \pm\pi/2$ blocks, each a J_2 . For $\delta \neq 0$, the parity factorization places the $4 \mid n$ excess in one protected J_2 .

It remains to distinguish one J_3 from two J_2 blocks in the tuned $n \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ case. Put $N_0 = L_n(1, 1) + 2I$ and $N = L_n(1, \omega_0) + 2I = N_0 - \delta dd^T$. Because $4 \nmid n$, zero is a semisimple eigenvalue of N_0 with eigenspace $E = \ker N_0$ of dimension n . Let Π be its spectral projection. Write

$$\det(tI - N_0) = t^n h(t), \quad h(0) \neq 0.$$

Semisimplicity gives $(tI - N_0)^{-1} = t^{-1}\Pi + O(1)$. The rank-one determinant formula then shows that the coefficient of t^{n-1} in $\det(tI - N)$ is $\delta h(0)d^\top \Pi d$. The multiplicity computation above shows that this coefficient vanishes for $n \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$, and therefore

$$d^\top \Pi d = 0. \quad (4.10)$$

The bulk relations derived above show directly that the eigenspace of N is $K = E \cap \ker d^\top$, which has dimension $n - 1$. If $v \in K \cap \text{ran } N$, write $v = Nu$ and apply Π :

$$v = \Pi Nu = -\delta \Pi d (d^\top u). \quad (4.11)$$

Thus $K \cap \text{ran } N$ has dimension at most one. For a finite matrix, every Jordan block of size at least two contributes its leading eigenvector to $\ker N \cap \text{ran } N$, these vectors are independent, and they span that intersection. The algebraic multiplicity exceeds the geometric multiplicity here, so the intersection has dimension one. Hence exactly one Jordan block at zero for N is nontrivial. It is a J_2 when the algebraic multiplicity is n , and the additional algebraic order at $\delta = -2/(n+1)$ makes that same block a J_3 . This proves all six cases and excludes the alternative of two J_2 blocks in the tuned case.

For completeness, put $A_-^{(0)} = L^{(0)}|_{\mathcal{H}_-}$ and consider an affected eigenvalue $\lambda \neq -2$. If $\delta \neq 0$, it cannot equal a nonflat homogeneous root: the corresponding residue in (4.3) is nonzero, so $Q_{n,-}$ does not vanish at that pole. Hence $\lambda I - A_-^{(0)}$ is invertible. The rank-one eigenvalue equation makes its eigenspace the one-dimensional span of $(\lambda I - A_-^{(0)})^{-1}d$. Its root order therefore gives the size of its unique Jordan block. If $\delta = 0$, all nonflat roots are simple by Lemma 4.6. This proves the final classification without asserting cyclicity at the removed flat primary component. ■

Corollary 4.9 (*Finite-ring algebraic exceptional locus*). *For fixed n , all non-flat affected exceptional parameters lie on the explicit algebraic set*

$$\text{Res}_\lambda(Q_{n,-}, \partial_\lambda Q_{n,-}) = 0,$$

with $Q_{n,-}$ given by (4.5). At $\omega = 1$, the flat factor is removed before taking the resultant. Root orders and theorems 4.7–4.8 distinguish exceptional points from semisimple parity crossings without a numerical tolerance.

Proof. The resultant vanishes exactly when the two displayed polynomials share a root. The preceding two theorems identify the Jordan block attached to every such root and separately account for the flat factor. ■

5. Defect-localized modes

Definition 5.1 (Bulk spectral set). For the infinite translation-invariant chain, define

$$\Sigma_\omega = \left\{ c - 1 - \omega \pm \sqrt{\omega^2 - (1 - c^2)} : c \in [-1, 1] \right\}.$$

For $\lambda \notin \Sigma_\omega$ with $a \neq 0$, retain a and x from (3.1)–(3.2), and choose

$$s(\lambda) = \sqrt{x(\lambda)^2 - 1}$$

as the standard branch on $x \in \mathbb{C} \setminus [-1, 1]$ satisfying $s/x \rightarrow 1$ as $|x| \rightarrow \infty$. Equivalently, it is the branch satisfying $s(\lambda) \sim x(\lambda)$ as $|\lambda| \rightarrow \infty$. Put $z = x - s$, so $|z| < 1$.

Let $L_\infty^{(0)}$ act on $\ell^2(\mathbb{Z}; \mathbb{C}^2)$ by (2.1)–(2.2) with every local rate equal to ω , and let $L_\infty = L_\infty^{(0)} - \delta d d^\top$, where now d is the polarization vector at the origin. These operators are bounded because they are finite linear combinations of bilateral shifts and bounded multiplication operators. Infinite-line eigenvalues below always mean ℓ^2 eigenvalues of L_∞ .

Theorem 5.2 (*Infinite-line localization criterion*). *Let $\delta \neq 0$ and $\lambda \notin \Sigma_\omega$. First suppose $a \neq 0$. Then λ is an exponentially localized eigenvalue of the infinite chain with the same single tumbling defect if and only if*

$$1 + 2\delta g_\infty(\lambda) = 0, \quad (5.1)$$

where

$$g_\infty(\lambda) = \frac{1}{2a} \left(1 + \frac{\lambda + 1 - x}{s} \right) = \frac{z(\lambda + 1 - z)}{a(1 - z^2)}. \quad (5.2)$$

The localization length is

$$\xi(\lambda) = \frac{-1}{\log |z|}.$$

Equivalently, with $a = \lambda + 1 + \omega$, the pair (a, z) satisfies

$$a^2 + 1 - \omega^2 - a(z + z^{-1}) = 0, \quad (5.3)$$

$$a(1 - z^2) + 2\delta z(a - \omega - z) = 0, \quad 0 < |z| < 1. \quad (5.4)$$

After elimination of a , every admissible z is a root of

$$\begin{aligned} 0 &= 2\delta z^3 + (2\delta\omega + 1 - \omega^2)z^2 \\ &\quad + (4\delta^2\omega + 4\delta\omega^2 - 2\delta)z + (2\delta\omega + \omega^2 - 1), \end{aligned} \quad (5.5)$$

and, when the denominator is nonzero,

$$a = \frac{2\delta z(\omega + z)}{1 - z^2 + 2\delta z}, \quad \lambda = a - 1 - \omega. \quad (5.6)$$

A root of (5.5) is accepted only when (5.1), or equivalently both (5.3) and (5.4), is satisfied; this removes roots introduced by elimination or by clearing denominators.

There is one additional compact case, at the point where $a = 0$. If $\omega \neq 1$, then

$$\lambda = -1 - \omega \quad \text{is localized if and only if} \quad \omega_0 = \frac{\omega^2 + 1}{2\omega}. \quad (5.7)$$

Its decay root is $z = 0$, its localization length is $\xi = 0$, and its eigenvector is supported at the defect and its two neighboring sites. Thus the admissible range in the preceding formulas is $0 < |z| < 1$; $z = 0$ is accepted precisely in (5.7).

Proof. The polarization entry of the bulk resolvent at the defect site is

$$\begin{aligned} g_\infty(\lambda) &= \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} \frac{\lambda + 1 - \cos q}{a^2 + 1 - \omega^2 - 2a \cos q} dq \\ &= \frac{1}{2a} \left[1 + (\lambda + 1 - x) \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} \frac{dq}{x - \cos q} \right] \\ &= \frac{1}{2a} \left(1 + \frac{\lambda + 1 - x}{s} \right). \end{aligned}$$

If $(\lambda - L_\infty)u = 0$, then

$$u = -\delta(\lambda - L_\infty^{(0)})^{-1} d(d^\top u).$$

The scalar $d^\top u$ cannot vanish unless $u = 0$. Applying $d^\top$ therefore gives (5.1). Conversely, when that scalar equation holds, the displayed resolvent vector is a nonzero ℓ^2 eigenvector. Since $x = (z + z^{-1})/2$ and $s = (z^{-1} - z)/2$, elementary simplification gives the second expression in (5.2), and the Green kernel decays as $z^{|j|}$. Clearing the denominator in (5.1) gives (5.4); the bulk dispersion relation gives (5.3). Eliminating a gives (5.5), while solving (5.4) for a gives (5.6).

It remains to evaluate the point omitted by division by a . At $\lambda = -1 - \omega$ the Fourier denominator is the nonzero constant $1 - \omega^2$, and hence

$$g_\infty(-1 - \omega) = \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} \frac{-\omega - \cos q}{1 - \omega^2} dq = \frac{\omega}{\omega^2 - 1}.$$

The secular equation is therefore equivalent to $\delta = (1 - \omega^2)/(2\omega)$, which is exactly (5.7). In Fourier variables the associated resolvent vector is proportional to

$$\begin{pmatrix} -\omega - e^{-iq} \\ \omega + e^{iq} \end{pmatrix}.$$

Its inverse Fourier transform is supported at the defect and its two neighbors. This proves the compact case and also shows directly that it is the limiting root $z = 0$. $\blacksquare$

Proposition 5.3 (*Finite-ring convergence of a localized mode*). Suppose (5.1) has a simple root λ_∞ with decay root z_∞ , $0 < |z_\infty| < 1$. Then, for all sufficiently large n , the finite polynomial $Q_{n,-}$ has a unique root λ_n near λ_∞ , and

$$\lambda_n - \lambda_\infty = O(|z_\infty|^n).$$

If the corresponding right eigenvector is normalized in ℓ^2 , define its site mass as $|u_j^+|^2 + |u_j^-|^2$. This mass is bounded by $C|z_\infty|^{2 \operatorname{dist}(j,0)}$. In the compact case (5.7), the infinite and finite eigenvalues agree exactly and the eigenvector is supported where $\operatorname{dist}(j,0) \leq 1$.

Proof. The root-of-unity sum of the bulk Green kernel is the exact identity

$$G_n(\lambda) = \frac{1}{2a} \left[1 + \frac{\lambda + 1 - x}{s} \frac{1 + z^n}{1 - z^n} \right]. \quad (5.8)$$

Indeed, Fourier expansion of $(x - \cos q)^{-1}$ gives

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \frac{1}{x - \cos q_k} = \frac{1}{s} \frac{1 + z^n}{1 - z^n}.$$

Both sides of (5.8) are meromorphic functions of λ . The identity therefore continues across the infinite-volume cut to every point away from a finite-ring homogeneous pole; the two boundary choices of s give the same continued function. Consequently

$$G_n - g_\infty = \frac{\lambda + 1 - x}{as} \frac{z^n}{1 - z^n}. \quad (5.9)$$

Choose a closed disk B about λ_∞ disjoint from Σ_ω and containing no other zero of $1 + 2\delta g_\infty$. Shrinking it if necessary, choose

$$\rho = \max_{\lambda \in B} |z(\lambda)| < r < 1.$$

Equation (5.9) and its λ -derivative are bounded on B by $C_B r^n$: for the derivative, the only additional factor is $n\rho^{n-1} = O(r^n)$. Rouché's theorem on ∂B , followed by the simple-zero estimate at λ_∞ , gives one zero λ_n and first yields $\lambda_n - \lambda_\infty = O(r^n)$. The root equation and (5.9) then give

$$|\lambda_n - \lambda_\infty| \leq C |z(\lambda_n)|^n.$$

Since $z_\infty \neq 0$ and $z(\lambda_n)/z_\infty = 1 + O(r^n)$, one has $|z(\lambda_n)/z_\infty|^n = \exp(O(nr^n)) = O(1)$. Hence $\lambda_n - \lambda_\infty = O(|z_\infty|^n)$.

The Fourier coefficients of the two bulk resolvent entries are linear combinations of $z^{|j|}$ and $z^{|j \pm 1|}$. Their periodizations are bounded by

$$\frac{r^{\text{dist}(j,0)} + r^{n-\text{dist}(j,0)}}{1 - r^n}.$$

The coefficients converge to their nonzero infinite-volume values, so normalization changes this bound by a fixed factor. Using $z(\lambda_n) = z_\infty + O(|z_\infty|^n)$ gives the stated site-mass estimate.

In the compact case, the Laurent-polynomial Fourier vector displayed in the proof of Theorem 5.2 is an exact finite-ring eigenvector for every n (with the two neighbors identified when $n = 2$), proving the last assertion. $\blacksquare$

6. Large-ring spectral gap

Definition 6.1 (Spectral gap). For $\omega > 0$ and $n \geq 2$, irreducibility makes zero a simple eigenvalue. Define

$$\gamma_n(\omega, \omega_0) = -\max\{\Re \lambda : \lambda \in \text{spec } L_n(\omega, \omega_0), \lambda \neq 0\}.$$

Put $q = 2\pi/n$ and define the protected first-mode decay rate

$$\gamma_n^{\text{hom}}(\omega) = 1 - \cos q + \omega - \sqrt{\omega^2 - \sin^2 q}, \quad (6.1)$$

where the square root is positive once n is sufficiently large for fixed $\omega > 0$. For each fixed ω , this rate equals the homogeneous spectral gap for all sufficiently large n ; no such identity is asserted for small n , where the tumble mode can be slower.

Lemma 6.2 (*Fixed-rate regular Green estimate*). *Let $K \subset (0, \infty) \times [0, \infty)$ be compact and let $A > 0$. For $(\omega, \omega_0) \in K$, put*

$$p_n = \lambda_1^+, \quad R_n = -\frac{\omega - r_1}{2r_1}, \quad r_1 = \sqrt{\omega^2 - \sin^2(2\pi/n)}.$$

For all sufficiently large n , define the regular part on $|\lambda - p_n| \leq An^{-3}$ by

$$G_n^{\text{reg}}(\lambda) = G_n(\lambda) - \frac{2R_n}{n(\lambda - p_n)}.$$

There is $C = C(K, A)$ such that throughout this disk

$$\left| G_n^{\text{reg}}(\lambda) - \frac{1}{2(1 + \omega)} \right| \leq \frac{C}{n}, \quad |(G_n^{\text{reg}})'(\lambda)| \leq Cn. \quad (6.2)$$

Proof. Write $q_k^* = 2\pi \min(k, n - k)/n$. Choose $\eta > 0$, uniformly for $(\omega, \omega_0) \in K$, so that $|\sin q| \leq \omega/2$ for $0 \leq q \leq \eta$. On this interval put

$$p^\pm(q) = \cos q - 1 - \omega \pm \sqrt{\omega^2 - \sin^2 q}, \quad R^+(q) = -\frac{\omega - \sqrt{\omega^2 - \sin^2 q}}{2\sqrt{\omega^2 - \sin^2 q}}.$$

Taylor's theorem with remainder, applied uniformly on the compact ω -projection of K , gives constants $c, C > 0$ such that

$$cq^2 \leq -p^+(q) \leq Cq^2, \quad |R^+(q)| \leq Cq^2, \quad (6.3)$$

$$|p^+(q_k^*) - p^+(q_1^*)| \geq c(k^2 - 1)n^{-2} \quad (2 \leq k \leq \eta n/(2\pi)). \quad (6.4)$$

For the last inequality, regard $p^+(q)$ as a function of q^2 ; its derivative at zero is $-(1 + \omega)/(2\omega)$ and, after decreasing η , its modulus is bounded below by a positive constant. The fast root $p^-(q)$ stays a fixed distance from zero on $[0, \eta]$. For $\eta \leq q \leq \pi$, both roots stay a fixed distance from zero: the real-part dissipation of the homogeneous Fourier block can vanish only at $q = 0$ in the density direction, and the Heine–Borel theorem applied to the remaining compact parameter set supplies a uniform positive distance.

For an interior paired wave number, partial fractions give

$$\frac{\lambda + 1 - \cos q_k}{D_k(\lambda)} = \frac{R^+(q_k^*)}{\lambda - p^+(q_k^*)} + \frac{1 - R^+(q_k^*)}{\lambda - p^-(q_k^*)}.$$

Let S_n be the convex hull of zero and $\{|\lambda - p_n| \leq An^{-3}\}$. Every point of S_n lies to the right of the second slow pole by at least $c(k^2 - 1)n^{-2}$ at index $k \geq 2$, after decreasing c and increasing n . Hence equations (6.3)–(6.4) bound the derivative of the regular slow-pole sum throughout S_n by

$$Cn \sum_{k=2}^{\infty} \frac{k^2}{(k^2 - 1)^2} \leq C'n.$$

The fast-pole terms, the wave numbers $q_k^* \geq \eta$, and the endpoint terms have total derivative $O(1)$. This proves the derivative bound in (6.2).

At $\lambda = 0$, every unpaired nonzero-wave Fourier summand is exactly $1/[2(1 + \omega)]$. The $q = 0$ term and the removed first-pole term each change the average by $O(n^{-1})$, using (6.3). Hence $G_n^{\text{reg}}(0) = 1/[2(1 + \omega)] + O(n^{-1})$. Finally $|p_n| = O(n^{-2})$, so integration of the derivative bound along the segment from zero to the displayed disk proves the first bound in (6.2). $\blacksquare$

Lemma 6.3 (*Protected first mode and affected pole*). *For every n , the protected sector contains $\lambda_1^+ = -\gamma_n^{\text{hom}}$. For fixed $\omega > 0$ and $\omega_0 \geq 0$, the affected root born from the same homogeneous pole is*

$$\lambda_{1,-} = \lambda_1^+ + \frac{\delta(1 + \omega)}{\omega^2(1 + \omega_0)} \frac{q^2}{n} + O(|\delta|n^{-4}). \quad (6.5)$$

Proof. The first assertion is Theorem 4.4. Near λ_1^+ , the two terms $k = 1, n - 1$ in the full Fourier Green function have residue

$$R_1 = \frac{\lambda_1^+ + 1 - c_1}{\lambda_1^+ - \lambda_1^-} = -\frac{\omega - r_1}{2r_1}, \quad r_1 = \sqrt{\omega^2 - \sin^2 q}.$$

Thus

$$G_n(\lambda) = \frac{2R_1}{n(\lambda - \lambda_1^+)} + G_n^{\text{reg}}(\lambda).$$

If $\delta = 0$, the affected root equals the protected root and the formula follows. Suppose $\delta \neq 0$ and put

$$M(\lambda) = 1 + 2\delta G_n^{\text{reg}}(\lambda), \quad M_0 = \frac{1 + \omega_0}{1 + \omega}.$$

Lemma 6.2 gives, uniformly on every fixed $O(n^{-3})$ disk about λ_1^+ ,

$$M(\lambda) = M_0 + O(|\delta|n^{-1}), \quad M'(\lambda) = O(|\delta|n).$$

The pole-cleared secular equation is

$$h_n(\lambda) := (\lambda - \lambda_1^+)M(\lambda) + \frac{4\delta R_1}{n} = 0.$$

Its affine comparison has the zero

$$\lambda_* - \lambda_1^+ = -\frac{4\delta R_1}{nM_0} = O(|\delta|n^{-3}).$$

On a circle of radius $C|\delta|n^{-4}$ about λ_* , the difference between h_n and $M_0(\lambda - \lambda_*)$ is at most $C_1\delta^2n^{-4} + O(\delta^2n^{-5})$. Since δ ranges over a fixed bounded set, choosing C larger than $C_1|\delta|/M_0$ makes the affine term strictly dominant. Rouché's theorem gives a unique root in this circle. Therefore

$$\lambda_{1,-} - \lambda_1^+ = \frac{2\delta(\omega - r_1)}{nr_1} \frac{1}{1 + \delta/(1 + \omega)} + O(|\delta|n^{-4}),$$

where the constant is uniform on the compact parameter sets of the lemma. Finally $(\omega - r_1)/r_1 = q^2/(2\omega^2) + O(q^4)$, which proves (6.5). $\blacksquare$

Lemma 6.4 (*Fixed-rate threshold Green bounds*). Fix a compact $K \subset (0, \infty) \times [0, \infty)$, put $D = (1 + \omega)/(2\omega)$ and $g_0 = 1/[2(1 + \omega)]$, and let $p_n = \lambda_1^+$. The following estimates hold uniformly for $(\omega, \omega_0) \in K$.

1. For every $M < \infty$ there is C_M such that, whenever $\lambda = \zeta/n^2$, $|\zeta| \leq M$, and

$$\begin{aligned} \Re \lambda &\geq \Re p_n - \pi^2 D n^{-2}, & |\lambda - p_n| &\geq A n^{-3}, & A &\geq 1, \\ |G_n(\lambda) - g_0| &\leq \frac{C_M}{A} + \frac{C_M}{n}. \end{aligned} \quad (6.6)$$

2. If $\lambda_n \rightarrow 0$ satisfies $-C n^{-2} \leq \Re \lambda_n \leq 0$ and $n^2 |\lambda_n| \rightarrow \infty$, then

$$G_n(\lambda_n) = g_0 + o(1). \quad (6.7)$$

Proof. Use the exact identities

$$x - 1 = \frac{\lambda(\lambda + 2\omega)}{2a}, \quad \lambda + 1 - x = \frac{\lambda(\lambda + 2)}{2a}. \quad (6.8)$$

For $\lambda = \zeta/n^2$, choose either local branch of $w_n = n \operatorname{arccosh} x$. Since all expressions below are even in w_n , the choice is immaterial. Taylor's theorem on $|\zeta| \leq M$ and (6.8) give

$$w_n^2 = \frac{\zeta}{D} + O_M(n^{-2}), \quad (6.9)$$

$$\frac{\lambda + 1 - x}{2a \sinh(w_n/n)} = \frac{w_n}{4\omega(1 + \omega)n} + O_M(n^{-3}). \quad (6.10)$$

Here the quotients at $w_n = 0$ mean their analytic continuations. To verify the second line without dividing by a small w_n , expand $\cosh(w_n/n) - 1 = x - 1$: it gives $\zeta = (1 + \omega)w_n^2/(2\omega) + O_M(n^{-2})$, and substitution into the second identity in (6.8) gives (6.10).

Since $z^n = e^{-w_n}$, the exact finite Green formula becomes

$$G_n(\zeta/n^2) = g_0 + \frac{w_n}{4\omega(1 + \omega)n} \coth(w_n/2) + E_n, \quad (6.11)$$

where

$$|E_n| \leq C_M n^{-2} + C_M n^{-3} |\coth(w_n/2)|.$$

The only nonzero pole in the stated scaled half-plane has $w_n = 2\pi i$ up to sign and is exactly $\lambda = p_n$. The derivative of the analytic map $\zeta \mapsto w_n$ at this pole is bounded above and below away from zero. The complex inverse-function theorem, uniformly on the compact parameter set, therefore gives $|w_n - 2\pi i| \geq cA/n$ outside $|\lambda - p_n| < A n^{-3}$. On a fundamental strip,

$$|\coth(w/2)| \leq C (1 + \operatorname{dist}(w, 2\pi i \mathbb{Z})^{-1}); \quad (6.12)$$

indeed, subtract the nearest $2\pi i \ell$, use $\sinh(w/2) = w/2 + O(w^3)$ for $|w| \leq 1$, and use continuity on the remaining closed strip together with $\coth(w/2) \rightarrow \pm 1$ as $\Re w \rightarrow \pm \infty$. Equations (6.11)–(6.12) prove (6.6).

For item 2, the real-part assumptions imply $|\Im \lambda_n|/|\lambda_n| \rightarrow 1$. By the first identity in (6.8), $x - 1$ lies, for large n , in one of two closed sectors about the positive or negative imaginary axis. The expansion

$$\operatorname{arccosh}(1 + u) = \sqrt{2u}(1 + O(u))$$

on those sectors gives $\Re \operatorname{arccosh} x \geq c\sqrt{|\lambda_n|}$. Hence

$$|z(\lambda_n)|^n \leq \exp(-cn\sqrt{|\lambda_n|}) \rightarrow 0.$$

Moreover, the two identities in (6.8) give $|(\lambda_n + 1 - x)/s| \leq C\sqrt{|\lambda_n|}$. Substitution in (5.8) now proves (6.7). $\blacksquare$

Lemma 6.5 (*Right-edge root separation*). *Fix $\omega > 0$ and $\omega_0 \geq 0$, and put $D = (1 + \omega)/(2\omega)$. There is N such that, for $n \geq N$, every nonzero eigenvalue other than the protected and affected roots born from $q = \pm 2\pi/n$ satisfies*

$$\Re \lambda \leq \Re \lambda_1^+ - \pi^2 D n^{-2}. \quad (6.13)$$

The constants can be chosen uniformly when (ω, ω_0) ranges over a compact set with ω bounded away from zero.

Proof. Put

$$\Omega_n = \{\lambda : \Re \lambda \geq \Re \lambda_1^+ - \pi^2 D n^{-2}\}.$$

The protected roots are explicit. Their slow branch satisfies, uniformly for small real q ,

$$\lambda^+(q) = -Dq^2 + O(q^4). \quad (6.14)$$

Choose $q_* > 0$ so that the remainder is at most $Dq^2/4$ for $|q| \leq q_*$. The modes with $2\pi/n < |q| \leq q_*$ are then to the left of Ω_n , while continuity puts both branches with $q_* \leq |q| \leq \pi$ a fixed distance into the left half-plane. The fast small- q branch is also separated from zero by a fixed amount. Thus, apart from zero, only the protected root born from $q = \pm 2\pi/n$ lies in Ω_n once n is large. We prove the same exclusion for the affected sector.

If $\delta = 0$, that sector is homogeneous and the conclusion follows from (6.14). Assume $\delta \neq 0$ and set

$$f_n(\lambda) = 1 + 2\delta G_n(\lambda), \quad g_0 = \frac{1}{2(1 + \omega)}, \quad M_0 = 1 + 2\delta g_0 = \frac{1 + \omega_0}{1 + \omega} > 0. \quad (6.15)$$

In a neighborhood of zero, every affected root is a zero of f_n . Indeed, the residue at every slow homogeneous pole is nonzero, so multiplication by $H_{n,-}^{(0)}$ cancels the pole of f_n but does not leave a zero there.

We first exclude affected zeros that do not tend to zero. Gershgorin's theorem places every finite-ring eigenvalue in a fixed disk and in the closed left half-plane. If the desired exclusion failed, there would be $\epsilon > 0$ and a sequence of affected zeros in Ω_n with $|\lambda| \geq \epsilon$; a subsequence would converge to $\lambda_* \neq 0$ with $\Re \lambda_* = 0$. For a bulk Bloch vector at wave number q , the real part of its quadratic form is the negative of $(1 - \cos q)$ times its squared

norm, together with the nonnegative tumbling form. Equality therefore forces $q = 0$ and equal orientation components, and the corresponding eigenvalue is zero. Thus the bulk spectral set meets the imaginary axis only at zero, so (5.9) gives $G_n \rightarrow g_\infty$ locally uniformly at λ_* . The limiting secular equation would produce an ℓ^2 eigenvector u of the infinite defective generator with eigenvalue λ_* . This is impossible because

$$-\Re\langle u, L_\infty u \rangle = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{j,\sigma} |u_{j+1}^\sigma - u_j^\sigma|^2 + \sum_j \omega_j |u_j^+ - u_j^-|^2. \quad (6.16)$$

Here (6.16) follows by expanding the inner product, shifting the two hopping sums, and pairing the two tumbling terms at each site. These operations are valid first for finitely supported vectors and then for all $u \in \ell^2$ by density and boundedness of L_∞ . Equality in (6.16) forces an ℓ^2 vector to vanish. The subsequence contradiction therefore supplies $\epsilon > 0$ such that no affected zero in Ω_n can satisfy $|\lambda| \geq \epsilon$.

It remains to exhaust the affected zeros that tend to zero. We first choose A so large that the local constant in Lemma 6.4, at the limiting first pole, obeys $2|\delta|C/A < M_0/4$. We claim that, after increasing n ,

$$|f_n(\lambda)| \geq \frac{M_0}{2} \quad (6.17)$$

throughout Ω_n near zero, apart from $|\lambda - \lambda_1^+| < An^{-3}$. Otherwise there would be a sequence λ_n violating (6.17). Pass to a subsequence according as $\zeta_n = n^2\lambda_n$ is bounded or unbounded. In the bounded case, pass once more so that $\zeta_n \rightarrow \zeta_*$. If ζ_* is not the limiting first pole, the expansion in the proof of Lemma 6.4 gives $G_n(\lambda_n) \rightarrow g_0$. If it is the limiting first pole, the first assertion of that lemma and the choice of A give $|G_n(\lambda_n) - g_0| \leq C/A + o(1)$. In both alternatives, $|f_n(\lambda_n)| > M_0/2$ for large n , a contradiction. In the unbounded case, the second assertion of the lemma gives $G_n(\lambda_n) = g_0 + o(1)$ and the same contradiction. This proves (6.17).

Finally, on the circle $|\lambda - \lambda_1^+| = An^{-3}$ write

$$G_n(\lambda) = \frac{2R_1}{n(\lambda - \lambda_1^+)} + G_n^{\text{reg}}(\lambda).$$

Lemma 6.2 and (6.15) give $1 + 2\delta G_n^{\text{reg}} = M_0 + O(n^{-1})$. After multiplication by $\lambda - \lambda_1^+$, the secular equation becomes

$$(\lambda - \lambda_1^+)f_n(\lambda) = M_0(\lambda - \lambda_1^+) + \frac{4\delta R_1}{n} + O(n^{-1}|\lambda - \lambda_1^+|). \quad (6.18)$$

Here $R_1 = O(n^{-2})$. Enlarge A , if necessary, so that the zero of the first two terms lies strictly inside the circle. On the circle the last term is $O(n^{-4})$, whereas the first two terms have modulus bounded below by $c_A n^{-3}$. Rouché's theorem therefore counts exactly one zero in the disk. It is the affected root of Lemma 6.3. Thus no other affected root occurs in Ω_n , which proves the assertion.

All estimates above are uniform on the stated compact parameter sets: D , δ , and the generator norms are bounded there, while M_0 has a positive minimum. $\blacksquare$

Theorem 6.6 (*Fixed-rate gap asymptotics*). Fix $\omega > 0$ and $\omega_0 \geq 0$.

1. If $\omega_0 \leq \omega$, then for every sufficiently large n ,

$$\gamma_n(\omega, \omega_0) = \gamma_n^{\text{hom}}(\omega). \quad (6.19)$$

2. If $\omega_0 > \omega$, then

$$\gamma_n(\omega, \omega_0) = \gamma_n^{\text{hom}}(\omega) - \frac{4\pi^2(\omega_0 - \omega)(1 + \omega)}{\omega^2(1 + \omega_0)} n^{-3} + O(|\omega_0 - \omega|n^{-4}). \quad (6.20)$$

3. In both cases,

$$\begin{aligned} \gamma_n^{\text{hom}}(\omega) &= \frac{2\pi^2(1 + \omega)}{\omega} n^{-2} \\ &\quad - 16\pi^4 \left(\frac{1}{24} + \frac{1}{6\omega} - \frac{1}{8\omega^3} \right) n^{-4} + O(n^{-6}). \end{aligned} \quad (6.21)$$

The errors are uniform when (ω, ω_0) ranges over a compact set with ω bounded away from zero. The root selection is uniform through $\omega_0 = \omega$, where the two parity roots coincide.

Proof. Taylor expansion of (6.1) gives (6.21). Lemma 6.3 shows that, uniformly across $\delta = 0$, the affected first root moves toward zero precisely when $\delta > 0$. Lemma 6.5 shows that no other extended, band-edge, or localized root can compete with this first pair. Therefore the protected root wins when $\delta \leq 0$, proving (6.19), and the affected root wins when $\delta > 0$. Substitution of $q^2 = 4\pi^2 n^{-2}$ in (6.5) then gives (6.20). ■

Corollary 6.7 (*Fixed ratio, vanishing ratio, and a slow-site scaling*). Let the bulk rate $\omega > 0$ be fixed.

1. If $\omega_0/\omega \rightarrow \rho \in (0, \infty)$, equations (6.19)–(6.21) apply. For $\rho < 1$ the protected branch is selected; for $\rho > 1$ the affected branch and its n^{-3} term are selected. At the boundary $\rho = 1$, the protected root is selected whenever $\omega_0 \leq \omega$ and the affected root whenever $\omega_0 > \omega$, with the expansion uniform across equality.
2. If $\omega_0/\omega \rightarrow 0$, then (6.19) holds for every sufficiently large n .
3. In particular, if $n\omega_0 \rightarrow \beta$ with $\beta \geq 0$, then (6.19) still holds. A single slow tumbling site therefore has no separate $\omega_0 \asymp n^{-1}$ gap crossover when the bulk rate is fixed.

Proof. In items 2 and 3 one has $\omega_0 < \omega$ for every sufficiently large n , so Theorem 6.6 applies. Item 1 follows by the same sign test and compact-uniform expansion. ■

Definition 6.8 (Critical homogeneous poles and residues). For $\omega = \alpha/n$ and $k = 2\pi$, put

$$\begin{aligned} p_{\ell,n}^{\pm} &= \cos(\ell k/n) - 1 - \frac{\alpha}{n} \pm \sqrt{\frac{\alpha^2}{n^2} - \sin^2(\ell k/n)}, \\ R_{\ell,n}^{\pm} &= \frac{p_{\ell,n}^{\pm} + 1 - \cos(\ell k/n)}{p_{\ell,n}^{\pm} - p_{\ell,n}^{\mp}}. \end{aligned} \quad (6.22)$$

When the two poles are distinct, their contribution to G_n is $2R_{\ell,n}^\pm/\{n(\lambda - p_{\ell,n}^\pm)\}$ for the indicated sign.

Lemma 6.9 (*Critical Green limit and pole remainders*). Set $\omega = \alpha/n$, where $\alpha > 0$ is fixed, and put $k = 2\pi$. For $\nu \in \mathbb{C}$, define the meromorphic function

$$\mathcal{G}_\alpha(\nu) = \frac{1}{2} \left[1 + \frac{\nu}{\kappa} \coth\left(\frac{\kappa}{2}\right) \right], \quad \kappa^2 = \nu(\nu + 2\alpha), \quad (6.23)$$

where the right-hand side is independent of the choice of square root and is interpreted by meromorphic continuation at $\kappa = 0$. Then:

1. $G_n(\nu/n) \rightarrow \mathcal{G}_\alpha(\nu)$ locally uniformly on every compact set containing no pole of (6.23).
2. Fix $\ell \geq 1$ with $\alpha \neq \ell k$, and let $p_{\ell,n}^\pm$ and $R_{\ell,n}^\pm$ be given by (6.22). There are $\eta, C > 0$ such that

$$\left| G_n(\lambda) - \frac{2R_{\ell,n}^\pm}{n(\lambda - p_{\ell,n}^\pm)} \right| \leq C \quad (6.24)$$

whenever $|n\lambda - np_{\ell,n}^\pm| \leq \eta$, for all sufficiently large n .

3. If $\alpha = k$, put

$$\lambda_c = \cos(k/n) - 1 - k/n, \quad r_n = \sqrt{(k/n)^2 - \sin^2(k/n)}.$$

There are $\eta, C > 0$ and analytic functions H_n on $|n(\lambda - \lambda_c)| \leq \eta$ such that

$$G_n(\lambda) = \frac{2(\lambda - \lambda_c - k/n)}{n\{(\lambda - \lambda_c)^2 - r_n^2\}} + H_n(\lambda), \quad |H_n(\lambda)| \leq C. \quad (6.25)$$

Proof. Let $w_n(\nu) = n \operatorname{arccosh} x(\nu/n)$ on any local branch. The exact identities (6.8) give

$$\cosh(w_n/n) = 1 + \frac{\nu(\nu + 2\alpha)}{2n^2\{1 + (\nu + \alpha)/n\}}, \quad (6.26)$$

$$\frac{\lambda + 1 - x}{s} = \frac{\nu(2 + \nu/n)}{2n\{1 + (\nu + \alpha)/n\} \sinh(w_n/n)}, \quad \lambda = \nu/n. \quad (6.27)$$

On a compact ν -set, Taylor's theorem applied to (6.26) yields $w_n^2 = \nu(\nu + 2\alpha) + O(n^{-1})$. Substitution of (6.27) into the exact formula (5.8), with $(1 + z^n)/(1 - z^n) = \coth(w_n/2)$, proves item 1. The formula is even in w_n , so the conclusion agrees on overlapping branch neighborhoods.

For item 2, the limiting poles are

$$\nu_\ell^\pm = -\alpha \pm \sqrt{\alpha^2 - \ell^2 k^2}.$$

The hypothesis $\alpha \neq \ell k$ makes them simple. Choose a closed disk U about one of them that contains no other limiting pole. For large n , $G_n(\nu/n)$ has exactly the corresponding pole $np_{\ell,n}^\pm$ in U , with principal part $2R_{\ell,n}^\pm/(\nu - np_{\ell,n}^\pm)$. Item 1 bounds both the Green function

and this principal part on ∂U . Their difference is analytic in U , so the maximum-modulus theorem bounds it throughout a smaller concentric disk. Replacing ν by $n\lambda$ gives (6.24).

When $\alpha = k$, the two first poles lie at $\lambda_c \pm r_n$. Adding their two summands in (4.3) gives exactly the displayed rational term in (6.25). Choose a fixed disk about $-k$ in the ν -plane that contains no other limiting pole. On its boundary, item 1 bounds $G_n(\nu/n)$ and direct inspection bounds the grouped term. Their difference is analytic inside because both first poles have been removed. The maximum-modulus theorem gives the asserted uniform bound on a smaller disk. $\blacksquare$

Lemma 6.10 (*Critical off-pole Green estimate*). *Fix $\alpha > 0$, put $\omega = \alpha/n$ and $k = 2\pi$, and restrict λ to an arbitrary fixed disk. The following estimates hold.*

1. Suppose $\alpha \leq k$. For an integer $L \geq 1$, set

$$B = \frac{k^2}{4}\{L^2 + (L+1)^2\}, \quad \Omega_{B,n} = \{\Re \lambda \geq -\alpha/n - B/n^2\}.$$

Delete the disks of radius An^{-2} about all simple homogeneous poles in $\Omega_{B,n}$. If $\alpha = k$, replace the two disks at the first poles by the disk of radius $An^{-3/2}$ about their midpoint. There are constants C and C_B , independent of A and n , such that on the remaining set, for $A \geq 1$ and all sufficiently large n ,

$$|G_n(\lambda)| \leq C_B \left(1 + \frac{n}{A}\right) + C \frac{n}{\sqrt{B}}. \quad (6.28)$$

2. Suppose $\alpha > k$. Define

$$d_1 = \alpha - \sqrt{\alpha^2 - k^2}, \quad d_2 = \alpha - \Re \sqrt{\alpha^2 - 4k^2},$$

choose $d \in (d_1, d_2)$, and put $\Omega_{d,n} = \{\Re \lambda \geq -d/n\}$. After deleting the disk of radius An^{-2} about the slow first pole, one has

$$|G_n(\lambda)| \leq C_d \left(1 + \frac{n}{A}\right) \quad (6.29)$$

throughout $\Omega_{d,n}$, for $A \geq 1$ and all sufficiently large n .

Proof. Write $w = n \operatorname{arccosh} x$ and $\Theta = (\lambda + 1 - x)/s$. Besides (5.8), we use the exact identity

$$\Theta^2 = \frac{\lambda(\lambda + 2)}{(\lambda + 2\omega)(\lambda + 2 + 2\omega)}. \quad (6.30)$$

It follows by squaring the second identity in (6.8) and using

$$x + 1 = \frac{(\lambda + 2)(\lambda + 2 + 2\omega)}{2a}.$$

The right-edge windows stay a fixed multiple of n^{-1} to the right of the tumble pole -2ω . Consequently $|a|$ is bounded below and $|\Theta|$ is bounded there. If w is near zero, the apparent singularity of the cotangent cancels: Taylor expansion in the two exact identities gives

$$\Theta \coth(w/2) = \frac{\lambda + 2}{n(\lambda + 2\omega)} + O(1), \quad (6.31)$$

uniformly in either window. This is bounded because $|\lambda + 2\omega| \geq c(n^{-1} + |\Im \lambda|)$. Away from $w = 0$, (5.8) and (6.12) therefore give

$$|G_n(\lambda)| \leq C \{1 + \text{dist}(w, 2\pi i\mathbb{Z})^{-1}\}. \quad (6.32)$$

We now bound the distance in (6.32). The exact factorization

$$2a\{\cosh(w/n) - \cos(\ell k/n)\} = D_\ell(\lambda) = (\lambda - p_{\ell,n}^+)(\lambda - p_{\ell,n}^-) \quad (6.33)$$

shows that $w = 2\pi i\ell$ precisely at the two poles with index ℓ . Suppose first that $\theta = w - 2\pi i\ell$ has $|\theta| < 1$, and choose the representative $q = \ell k/n \in [0, \pi]$. Taylor's theorem gives the uniform upper bound

$$|D_\ell(\lambda)| \leq C \left(\frac{|\sin q|}{n} |\theta| + \frac{|\theta|^2}{n^2} \right). \quad (6.34)$$

For each of the finitely many simple poles inside $\Omega_{B,n}$, the scaled map $\nu = n\lambda \mapsto w$ has a derivative bounded above and below at the pole. The inverse-function theorem and compactness of the boundaries of fixed scaled neighborhoods therefore give $|w - 2\pi i\ell| \geq cA/n$ off the deleted disk, once $n \geq N(A, B)$. At $\alpha = k$, write $\Delta = \lambda - \lambda_c$. If $|\Delta| \geq An^{-3/2}$, then

$$|D_1(\lambda)| = |\Delta^2 - r_n^2| \geq cA^2n^{-3}, \quad r_n = O(n^{-2}),$$

and (6.34), with $|\sin(k/n)| \asymp n^{-1}$, gives $|w - 2\pi i| \geq cA^2/n \geq cA/n$.

It remains to control the first pole just outside $\Omega_{B,n}$. Choose $q_0 \in (0, \pi/2)$. For $q \leq q_0$ and exterior $\ell \geq L+1$, the two poles are conjugate for large n ; write them $h_{\ell,n} \pm it_{\ell,n}$. Their horizontal distance from the window is

$$u_{\ell,n} = 1 - \cos(\ell k/n) - B/n^2.$$

The midpoint definition of B and the expansion $1 - \cos q = q^2/2 + O(q^4)$ show first that $u_{L+1,n} \geq c\sqrt{B}n^{-2}$ and then, by monotonicity of $1 - \cos q$ on $[0, q_0]$, that the same lower bound holds for every such exterior index. Moreover $t_{\ell,n} = \sqrt{\sin^2 q - \alpha^2/n^2} \geq cq$ because $\ell \geq L+1 \geq 2$ and $\alpha \leq k$. For $u \geq 0$ and real y, t ,

$$|(u + i(y - t))(u + i(y + t))| \geq 2u|t|; \quad (6.35)$$

this follows by squaring both sides and completing the square in y^2 . Consequently the right side of (6.33) is at least $cu_{\ell,n}q$. Since $q \geq 2k/n$ and $|\theta| < 1$, (6.34) is at most $Cq|\theta|/n$. Hence $|\theta| \geq cnu_{\ell,n} \geq c\sqrt{B}/n$.

For $q \in [q_0, \pi]$, both homogeneous poles have real part at most $-c(q_0) < 0$, whereas the window boundary tends to zero. Thus $|D_\ell(\lambda)| \geq c(q_0)^2$. This contradicts (6.34) when $|\theta| < 1$ and n is large, so in this range the distance is at least one. We have proved

$$\text{dist}(w, 2\pi i\mathbb{Z}) \geq c \min\{1, A/n, \sqrt{B}/n\}$$

outside the deleted disks. Combining this with (6.32) proves item 1.

For $\alpha > k$, the choice $d_1 < d < d_2$ leaves only the slow first pole in $\Omega_{d,n}$. The scaled inverse-function argument gives distance cA/n off its disk. Every other fixed-index pole is separated from the window by a positive constant on the $n\lambda$ scale, so the same argument gives distance c there. For growing indices, the horizontal separation increases until q is bounded below, where the last fixed-distance argument above applies. Thus $\text{dist}(w, 2\pi i\mathbb{Z}) \geq c \min\{1, A/n\}$, and equation (6.32) proves item 2. $\blacksquare$

Definition 6.11 (Critical first cluster). Fix a sufficiently large constant A . If $\alpha \neq k$, the critical first cluster consists, with algebraic multiplicity, of the protected roots $p_{1,n}^\pm$ and the affected roots in the two disks $|\lambda - p_{1,n}^\pm| < An^{-2}$. If $\alpha = k$, it consists of the two protected roots and all affected roots in the disk centered at $\lambda_c = \cos(k/n) - 1 - k/n$ given by

$$|\lambda - \lambda_c| < An^{-3/2}.$$

The root counts in the proof below show that this definition is independent of any further increase of A once n is sufficiently large.

Lemma 6.12 (Critical right-edge exhaustion). Set $\omega = \alpha/n$ and $\omega_0 = \beta/n$, where $\alpha > 0$ and $\beta \geq 0$ are fixed, and put $k = 2\pi$. For all sufficiently large n , every nonzero eigenvalue with maximal real part belongs to the critical first cluster of Definition 6.11. More precisely, if $\Lambda_{1,n}$ is the largest real part within that cluster, then every eigenvalue outside the cluster satisfies

$$\Re \lambda \leq \Lambda_{1,n} - \begin{cases} cn^{-2}, & \alpha \leq k, \\ cn^{-1}, & \alpha > k, \end{cases} \quad (6.36)$$

for a constant $c = c(\alpha, \beta) > 0$.

Proof. The protected roots are the homogeneous roots from Definition 6.8. Put $b = \beta - \alpha$. If $b = 0$, the affected polynomial is the homogeneous odd factor, so the assertion follows directly from the displayed dispersion; the shift formula (6.39) below then holds with zero shift. Assume $b \neq 0$.

Gershgorin's theorem confines all eigenvalues to a fixed disk. If $\alpha \leq k$, choose a midpoint value B from Lemma 6.10, first so large that the protected first root lies strictly inside $\Omega_{B,n}$ and then so that $2|b|C/\sqrt{B} < 1/8$. Next choose A so that $2|b|C_B/A < 1/8$, and finally increase n until $2|b|C_B/n < 1/4$. If $\alpha > k$, use the window $\Omega_{d,n}$ from item 2 of that lemma, choose A so that $2|b|C_d/A < 1/4$, and then increase n so that $2|b|C_d/n < 1/4$. Since $2\delta = 2b/n$, the two off-pole estimates give in either case

$$|2\delta G_n(\lambda)| < \frac{1}{2}. \quad (6.37)$$

Thus every affected zero in the chosen right-edge window lies in one of the pole neighborhoods specified in that lemma.

For a simple pole in one of these neighborhoods, Lemma 6.9 gives

$$G_n(\lambda) = \frac{2R_{\ell,n}^\pm}{n(\lambda - p_{\ell,n}^\pm)} + G_{\ell,n}^{\text{reg}}(\lambda), \quad G_{\ell,n}^{\text{reg}} = O(1).$$

Multiplication of the secular equation by $\lambda - p_{\ell,n}^\pm$ gives

$$(\lambda - p_{\ell,n}^\pm)(1 + 2\delta G_n) = (\lambda - p_{\ell,n}^\pm) \left(1 + \frac{2b}{n} G_{\ell,n}^{\text{reg}} \right) + \frac{4bR_{\ell,n}^\pm}{n^2}. \quad (6.38)$$

Compare the right-hand side with

$$h_0(\lambda) = \lambda - p_{\ell,n}^\pm + 4bR_{\ell,n}^\pm n^{-2}.$$

Enlarge A once more so that the zero of h_0 is strictly inside the disk. On its boundary, the difference from h_0 is $O(n^{-3})$, whereas $|h_0| \geq c_A n^{-2}$. Rouché's theorem gives exactly one affected zero and

$$\hat{p}_{\ell,n}^\pm = p_{\ell,n}^\pm - 4bR_{\ell,n}^\pm n^{-2} + O(n^{-3}). \quad (6.39)$$

Together with (6.37), this accounts for every affected root in either right-edge window except the grouped first neighborhood at $\alpha = k$, which belongs to the first cluster by Definition 6.11.

At $\alpha = k$, Lemma 6.9 gives, with $\Delta = \lambda - \lambda_c$,

$$(\Delta^2 - r_n^2)(1 + 2\delta G_n) = (\Delta^2 - r_n^2) \left(1 + \frac{2b}{n} H_n \right) + \frac{4b}{n^2} (\Delta - k/n). \quad (6.40)$$

On $|\Delta| = An^{-3/2}$, compare this with

$$P_{0,n}(\Delta) = \Delta^2 - r_n^2 + \frac{4b}{n^2} (\Delta - k/n).$$

For fixed nonzero b and sufficiently large A , both zeros of $P_{0,n}$ lie strictly inside the circle. The difference between the two sides is $O(A^2 n^{-4})$, whereas $|P_{0,n}| \geq c_A n^{-3}$ on the circle. Rouché's theorem therefore gives exactly two affected roots in the grouped disk. If $b = 0$, these are the two homogeneous odd-sector roots. This proves the asserted root count and the independence from increasing A in Definition 6.11.

Suppose first that $\alpha < k$. For every fixed $\ell \geq 1$, the two poles are nonreal conjugates and

$$\Re R_{\ell,n}^\pm = \frac{1}{2}, \quad \Re p_{\ell,n}^\pm = -\frac{\alpha}{n} - \frac{\ell^2 k^2}{2n^2} + O(n^{-4}). \quad (6.41)$$

Equations (6.39)–(6.41) show that the same parity is selected for every fixed ℓ , and that the $\ell = 2$ cluster is to the left of the first by $3k^2/(2n^2) + O(n^{-3})$. The choice of B puts every possible competitor either among these finitely many clusters or to their left and separates all roots outside the window from the first cluster by a fixed multiple of n^{-2} . The endpoint tumble root has real part $-2\alpha/n + O(n^{-2})$. This proves (6.36) for $\alpha < k$.

At $\alpha = k$, the first protected cluster contains

$$-\frac{k}{n} + \left(-\frac{k^2}{2} + \frac{k^2}{\sqrt{3}} \right) n^{-2} + O(n^{-3}). \quad (6.42)$$

For every fixed $\ell \geq 2$, equations (6.39)–(6.41) apply with $\alpha = k$. If $\beta \leq k$, its largest possible real part is below (6.42) by

$$\left[\frac{(\ell^2 - 1)k^2}{2} + \frac{k^2}{\sqrt{3}} - 2(k - \beta) \right] n^{-2} + O(n^{-3}),$$

which is positive because $k > 2\sqrt{3}$. If $\beta > k$, the affected higher modes move to the left and the protected comparison is even stronger. Estimate (6.37) accounts for all remaining affected roots, proving the assertion at $\alpha = k$.

Finally, if $\alpha > k$, the first slow pole has decay coefficient $d_1 = \alpha - \sqrt{\alpha^2 - k^2}$. By the choice of d , the only protected pole in $\Omega_{d,n}$ is the first slow pole, and (6.37)–(6.39) show that its affected partner is the only affected root there. Both have real part $-d_1/n + O(n^{-2})$, whereas every root outside the window has real part at most $-d/n$. This gives a separation of order n^{-1} and completes the proof. $\blacksquare$

Theorem 6.13 (*Bulk-critical double scaling*). *Set*

$$\omega = \frac{\alpha}{n}, \quad \omega_0 = \frac{\beta}{n}, \quad k = 2\pi,$$

where $\alpha > 0$ and $\beta \geq 0$ are fixed. Away from $\alpha = k$,

$$\alpha < k : \quad \gamma_n = \frac{\alpha}{n} + \left[\frac{k^2}{2} - 2(\alpha - \beta)_+ \right] n^{-2} + O(n^{-3}), \quad (6.43)$$

$$\begin{aligned} \alpha > k : \quad \gamma_n &= \frac{\alpha - \sqrt{\alpha^2 - k^2}}{n} \\ &+ \left[\frac{k^2}{2} - 2(\beta - \alpha)_+ \frac{\alpha - \sqrt{\alpha^2 - k^2}}{\sqrt{\alpha^2 - k^2}} \right] n^{-2} + O(n^{-3}). \end{aligned} \quad (6.44)$$

At $\alpha = k$,

$$\beta \leq k : \quad \gamma_n = \frac{k}{n} + k^2 \left(\frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{\sqrt{3}} \right) n^{-2} + O(n^{-3}), \quad (6.45)$$

$$\beta > k : \quad \gamma_n = \frac{k}{n} - 2\sqrt{k(\beta - k)} n^{-3/2} + O(n^{-2}). \quad (6.46)$$

Thus the first homogeneous exceptional scaling is a square-root boundary layer for a faster defect, while the side selecting the affected parity mode reverses as α passes through 2π .

Proof. For $\alpha < k$, the protected first pair has

$$\Re \lambda_1^+ = -\frac{\alpha}{n} - \frac{k^2}{2n^2} + O(n^{-3}).$$

The pole residue tends to $R_1 = \frac{1}{2} + i\alpha/(2\sqrt{k^2 - \alpha^2})$, and $\delta = (\beta - \alpha)/n$. Hence the affected real part shifts by $-2(\beta - \alpha)n^{-2} + O(n^{-3})$ by (6.39). Taking the larger real part gives (6.43).

For $\alpha > k$, put $s = \sqrt{\alpha^2 - k^2}$. The protected rate is $(\alpha - s)n^{-1} + k^2(2n^2)^{-1} + O(n^{-3})$, while $R_1 \rightarrow -(\alpha - s)/(2s)$. The same pole equation shifts the affected eigenvalue by $2(\beta - \alpha)(\alpha - s)/(sn^2) + O(n^{-3})$. Selection of the larger real part gives (6.44). Lemma 6.12 shows in both cases that no root outside the first cluster can compete with the selected root.

At $\alpha = k$, the exact lattice splitting of the homogeneous first block is

$$\sqrt{\omega^2 - \sin^2(k/n)} = \frac{k^2}{\sqrt{3}n^2} + O(n^{-4}),$$

which proves (6.45) when the protected root wins. Near the center of this block, put

$$\lambda_c = \cos(k/n) - 1 - k/n, \quad r_n = \sqrt{(k/n)^2 - \sin^2(k/n)}, \quad \Delta = \lambda - \lambda_c.$$

Lemma 6.9 gives the uniform identity

$$G_n(\lambda) = \frac{2(\Delta - k/n)}{n(\Delta^2 - r_n^2)} + H_n(\lambda), \quad |H_n(\lambda)| \leq C, \quad (6.47)$$

throughout a fixed $n\Delta$ -neighborhood of zero. In particular this bound is uniform on every contour used below.

For $\beta > k$, put $b = \beta - k$, $\epsilon = n^{-1/2}$, and $\Delta = n^{-3/2}Y$. Since

$$n^4 r_n^2 = \frac{k^4}{3} + O(n^{-2}),$$

the secular equation, uniformly for Y in a compact set bounded away from zero, is

$$F_n(Y) = 1 - \frac{4kb}{Y^2} + \frac{4b\epsilon}{Y} + O(\epsilon^2) = 0. \quad (6.48)$$

The limiting function has simple zeros $Y_{\pm} = \pm 2\sqrt{kb}$. On $|Y - Y_{\pm}| = C\epsilon$, its modulus is bounded below by $cC\epsilon$, while the difference in (6.48) is at most $C_1\epsilon$. Choosing $C > C_1/c$, Rouché's theorem gives one zero in each disk and hence two affected roots

$$\Delta = \pm 2\sqrt{kb} n^{-3/2} + O(n^{-2}).$$

The positive displacement gives (6.46).

For $\beta < k$, put $h = k - \beta > 0$. With the same scaling, the secular equation is

$$\tilde{F}_n(Y) = 1 + \frac{4kh}{Y^2} - \frac{4h\epsilon}{Y} + O(\epsilon^2) = 0. \quad (6.49)$$

Its two leading zeros are $Y_{\pm} = \pm 2i\sqrt{kh}$. Substitution shows that $Y_{\pm} + 2h\epsilon$ has residual $O(\epsilon^2)$. On the circles $|Y - (Y_{\pm} + 2h\epsilon)| = C\epsilon^2$, the affine part has modulus at least $cC\epsilon^2$ and the remaining error is at most $C_1\epsilon^2$. A second application of Rouché's theorem therefore gives the affected pair

$$\Delta = \pm 2i\sqrt{kh} n^{-3/2} + 2hn^{-2} + O(n^{-5/2}). \quad (6.50)$$

Its decay rate exceeds the protected decay rate by

$$\left(\frac{k^2}{\sqrt{3}} - 2h \right) n^{-2} + O(n^{-5/2}).$$

This coefficient is positive for $0 < h \leq k$ because $k = 2\pi > 2\sqrt{3}$. The protected root therefore wins for every $\beta < k$; at $\beta = k$ the two parity roots coincide. This proves (6.45); the case $\beta > k$ was obtained from the positive displacement above. Lemma 6.12 supplies the required exclusion of every higher, endpoint, and off-pole affected root in both cases. ■

7. Telegraph comparison

Definition 7.1 (Two continuum approximations). For a homogeneous ring of circumference n , the standard telegraph system is

$$\partial_t \rho = -\partial_x m, \quad \partial_t m = -\partial_x \rho - 2\omega m. \quad (7.1)$$

Its slow Fourier eigenvalue at wave number q is

$$\lambda_{\text{tel}}^+(q) = -\omega + \sqrt{\omega^2 - q^2}. \quad (7.2)$$

The lattice-diffusion-corrected system is

$$\partial_t \rho = -\partial_x m + \frac{1}{2} \partial_x^2 \rho, \quad \partial_t m = -\partial_x \rho + \frac{1}{2} \partial_x^2 m - 2\omega m. \quad (7.3)$$

Its slow eigenvalue is

$$\lambda_{\text{td}}^+(q) = -\frac{q^2}{2} - \omega + \sqrt{\omega^2 - q^2}. \quad (7.4)$$

Lemma 7.2 (*Second-order lattice expansion*). Let $\rho, m \in C^4(\mathbb{R}/n\mathbb{Z})$ and sample $u_j^\pm = \{\rho(j) \pm m(j)\}/2$. The homogeneous lattice generator induces

$$\begin{aligned} \dot{\rho}_j &= -m'(j) + \frac{1}{2} \rho''(j) + r_{\rho,j}, \\ \dot{m}_j &= -\rho'(j) + \frac{1}{2} m''(j) - 2\omega m(j) + r_{m,j}, \end{aligned} \quad (7.5)$$

where

$$\begin{aligned} |r_{\rho,j}| &\leq \frac{1}{6} \|m'''\|_\infty + \frac{1}{24} \|\rho^{(4)}\|_\infty, \\ |r_{m,j}| &\leq \frac{1}{6} \|\rho'''\|_\infty + \frac{1}{24} \|m^{(4)}\|_\infty. \end{aligned} \quad (7.6)$$

Thus (7.3) is the second-order long-wave truncation of the lattice equations, with the remainder controlled in the sampled ℓ^∞ norm by (7.6).

Proof. Adding and subtracting the two homogeneous equations (2.1)–(2.2) gives the exact sampled identities

$$\begin{aligned} \dot{\rho}_j &= \frac{\rho(j-1) + \rho(j+1)}{2} - \rho(j) + \frac{m(j-1) - m(j+1)}{2}, \\ \dot{m}_j &= \frac{\rho(j-1) - \rho(j+1)}{2} + \frac{m(j-1) + m(j+1)}{2} - m(j) - 2\omega m(j). \end{aligned}$$

Taylor's theorem on the unit intervals adjacent to j bounds the error in each centered first difference by one sixth of the supremum of the third derivative, and the error in each centered second difference by one twenty-fourth of the supremum of the fourth derivative. Substitution gives (7.5)–(7.6). ■

Theorem 7.3 (*Exact relaxation rate versus telegraph rates*). Fix $\omega > 0$, let $q = 2\pi/n$, and define $\gamma_{\text{tel}} = -\lambda_{\text{tel}}^+(q)$ and $\gamma_{\text{td}} = -\lambda_{\text{td}}^+(q)$. Then

$$\gamma_n^{\text{hom}} - \gamma_{\text{tel}} = \frac{q^2}{2} - \left(\frac{1}{24} + \frac{1}{6\omega} \right) q^4 + O(q^6), \quad (7.7)$$

$$\gamma_n^{\text{hom}} - \gamma_{\text{td}} = - \left(\frac{1}{24} + \frac{1}{6\omega} \right) q^4 + O(q^6). \quad (7.8)$$

Consequently

$$\frac{\gamma_{\text{tel}}}{\gamma_n^{\text{hom}}} \longrightarrow \frac{1}{1+\omega}, \quad \frac{\gamma_{\text{td}}}{\gamma_n^{\text{hom}}} \longrightarrow 1. \quad (7.9)$$

In the bulk-critical scaling $\omega = \alpha/n$, the standard telegraph rate does recover the leading term:

$$\gamma_{\text{tel}} = \frac{\alpha - \Re \sqrt{\alpha^2 - (2\pi)^2}}{n}, \quad (7.10)$$

which agrees with the leading terms of (6.43)–(6.46).

Proof. The exact lattice dispersion replaces $-q^2/2$ by $\cos q - 1$ and q inside the square root by $\sin q$. Expanding $\cos q$, $\sin^2 q$, and the square root gives (7.7)–(7.8). Dividing by the leading exact rate $(1+\omega)q^2/(2\omega)$ gives (7.9). Substitution of $\omega = \alpha/n$ and $q = 2\pi/n$ into (7.2) gives (7.10). ■

Proposition 7.4 (*Point-defect telegraph secular equation*). On the circle cut at zero, define the point-defect telegraph operator by

$$\mathcal{A}_\delta(\rho, m) = (-m', -\rho' - 2\omega m) \quad \text{on } (0, n),$$

with domain consisting of $m, \rho \in H^1(0, n)$ having traces that satisfy

$$m(0+) = m(n-), \quad \rho(0+) - \rho(n-) = -2\delta m(0). \quad (7.11)$$

This is the distributional realization obtained by adding $-2\delta \delta_0(x)m$ to the second equation in (7.1). Outside the homogeneous telegraph spectrum, put

$$\kappa = \sqrt{\lambda(\lambda + 2\omega)}$$

and interpret $\kappa^{-1} \coth(n\kappa/2)$ as the even meromorphic function of κ obtained by analytic continuation; no sign choice for the square root is required. The affected-parity eigenvalues satisfy

$$1 + \delta \frac{\lambda}{\kappa} \coth\left(\frac{n\kappa}{2}\right) = 0. \quad (7.12)$$

For the involution

$$\mathcal{R}(\rho, m)(x) = (\rho(n-x), -m(n-x)),$$

the reflection-even telegraph modes are unchanged. Formula (7.12) is the continuum counterpart of (3.8); the exact lattice formula retains $1 - \cos q$ and $\sin q$, and (7.7)–(7.8) quantify the resulting relaxation-rate error.

Proof. The jump in (7.11) cancels the delta distribution in $-\rho' - 2\delta\delta_0 m(0)$, while continuity of m prevents a delta distribution in $-m'$. Thus the stated domain gives the point interaction on $L^2((0, n); \mathbb{C}^2)$. It is densely defined because it contains $C_c^\infty((0, n); \mathbb{C}^2)$, and it is closed: the graph norm controls $\|m'\|_2$ directly and controls $\|\rho'\|_2$ by $\|\rho'\|_2 \leq \|(\mathcal{A}_\delta(\rho, m))_2\|_2 + 2\omega\|m\|_2$; the trace theorem then preserves (7.11) under graph-norm limits.

Let λ lie outside the homogeneous telegraph spectrum. The eigenvalue equations away from zero are

$$-m' = \lambda\rho, \quad -\rho' - 2\omega m = \lambda m.$$

Thus $\lambda \neq 0$ and elimination of ρ gives $m'' = \kappa^2 m$. Write

$$m(x) = A \cosh(\kappa(x - n/2)) + B \sinh(\kappa(x - n/2)).$$

The equality $m(0) = m(n)$ gives $B = 0$, since $\sinh(n\kappa/2) = 0$ would put λ in the homogeneous spectrum. Using $\rho = -m'/\lambda$, the second jump condition in (7.11) is equivalent to

$$m'(0) - m'(n) = 2\delta\lambda m(0). \quad (7.13)$$

Substitution of the even hyperbolic-cosine solution into (7.13) gives

$$-2\kappa \sinh(n\kappa/2) = 2\delta\lambda \cosh(n\kappa/2),$$

which is exactly (7.12).

Equivalently, the polarization entry of the homogeneous telegraph resolvent is

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{\ell \in \mathbb{Z}} \frac{\lambda}{\lambda(\lambda + 2\omega) + (2\pi\ell/n)^2} = \frac{\lambda}{2\kappa} \coth\left(\frac{n\kappa}{2}\right).$$

The series converges normally away from the homogeneous spectrum and the last expression supplies its meromorphic continuation when κ is purely imaginary, in agreement with the direct jump calculation. Finally, a reflection-even vector satisfies $m(0+) = -m(n-)$; continuity of m therefore gives $m(0) = 0$. The jump vanishes, so these modes are protected exactly as in Lemma 4.2. ■

8. Conclusions

Remark 8.1 (The theorem package). For the generator in Definition 2.1:

1. Theorem 3.3 and Theorem 3.4 give exact characteristic equations for every n , ω , and ω_0 ; the trace equation is used away from its denominators and its cleared polynomial identity is used at their zeros.
2. Theorems 4.7 and 4.8 classify the algebraic and geometric multiplicities of every eigenvalue, including every exceptional point.
3. Theorem 5.2 gives an exact criterion and decay length for a defect-localized mode, and Proposition 5.3 gives its finite-ring convergence.

4. Theorems 6.6 and 6.13 give the fixed-rate, vanishing-defect, and bulk-critical large- n gap asymptotics.
5. Lemma 7.2, Theorem 7.3, and Proposition 7.4 derive the corrected continuum system and compare the exact relaxation rate with the standard and diffusion-corrected telegraph approximations.

Each item retains the hypotheses stated in its cited theorem: in particular, localization is asserted off the bulk spectrum (with the compact case treated separately), finite-ring localization convergence assumes a simple noncompact root, and the gap results use their stated fixed-rate or double-scaling regimes.

AI-use disclosure

The proof architecture and manuscript were developed with assistance from OpenAI GPT-5.6 Sol (gpt-5.6-sol) at max reasoning effort. The model served as an interactive research assistant for deriving and testing arguments, checking citations and calculations, writing exact verification code, and editing the exposition. The author set the research direction, evaluated and approved the final arguments, and assumes responsibility for the mathematical claims, references, computations, and text.

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